

Q You repeatedly say that Linux jobs are on the rise, globally. What gives you the confidence to say that?

As the engineering vice president of SUSE, I have been hiring a lot of people in the last few years. If you look at our website, we constantly have 15-35 engineering job openings for SUSE, depending on our approvals and requirement. So, SUSE is growing and so is its engineering team. We are doing well as a company, but I think Linux, in general, is doing great and is witnessing tremendous growth. A lot of traditional companies that used proprietary operating systems for their own development work have now taken serious cognisance of Linux. After adoption of Linux, obviously they need some expertise in-house, which is where you see the demand for Linux professionals. There are times when companies realise that they need expertise and they contact companies like us.

We are seeing a general trend towards open source and Linux. A number of companies that have never used it before are now considering it, and are contacting us as an enterprise partner to help them with that. So, in that context, we are growing with these partners and hiring engineers. Also, there are some technology areas that are particularly hot for Linux, like the areas around the cloud. Everything is new in this space, so there is no legacy. It has not been done with a different operating system earlier, so now that it is starting out, it is beginning with Linux. Another big area is mobile computing on smartphones, tablets and netbooks that run Android and Linux. This is why I say that Linux jobs are on the rise.

Q You just mentioned that the smartphone and tablet space is getting hotter. What is holding back SUSE from entering this space?

Frankly, business in this space is difficult. Everybody likes this space but the margins there are very, very small. We have had a lot of requests from people wanting to work with us but given the fact that there is very tough competition in these segments, margins are reduced to a minimum. It's actually hard to make money in that space. The mobile and tablet space will definitely continue to grow, Linux and Android adoption will also continue but I am not sure if we would like to get into something that has very slim profit margins to offer. We don't have any active plans to enter this space anytime soon, but of course, if we are able to cut a big contract, we would be willing to try it out. But so far, the business cases that have been presented to us have not been interesting enough. There have been big OEMs who came to us, but we were not impressed by the deal we were offered.

So, it's not about big OEM partners, it's about the business case we get. Just because everyone is doing it, we will not do it. We are a professional business company and so we look at the business case. We make upfront investments only if we see long term returns. Getting into the smartphone

or tablet space is a feasible option only when you have enormous volumes.

It may sound strange but have a look at the companies with operating systems... how many of them are really making money out of the operating systems is the real question. Google is giving Android away for free. Besides, I cannot see a platform which is anyways a success, be it in terms of popularity or in terms of making money. Hype doesn't mean money!

OpenSUSE 12.3: Sheenless but feature-rich

Q Let's talk about your latest release OpenSUSE 12.3. It comes with a lot of improvements in terms of features but doesn't have the cosmetic changes. What stops you from doing the cosmetic enhancements to the product?

I think it's a question of how much effort can be put into every SUSE release vis-a-vis how much effort you can put into an enterprise release. The OpenSUSE products come out every eight months, so they have to be churned out very quickly and they are available to the users for free. There is cost but no revenue involved in it. So, I do not have the capacity to make OpenSUSE very great, but I need my engineers to make our enterprise very nice and stable, and ensure that everything works nicely. Contrary to our competitors like Ubuntu, who see the consumer market as their business model, SUSE sees the enterprise market as its business model. We absolutely leverage the open source development model and we contribute a lot back. There are quite a few areas where we are ahead of our competitors and we are investing in those areas. But when it comes to things like artwork and themes, it takes a lot of time and investment, which we would like to put into our enterprise version of the operating system. At the end of the day, the investment we put in the free products is certainly limited compared to the enterprise products, for which the customers pay.

Q What are the highlights of OpenSUSE 12.3, according to you?

First of all, it is going to be the base of our next enterprise product. So, a lot of technology seen in OpenSUSE 12.3 will become the standard not only for the SUSE Linux enterprise version but also for all major Linux distros. Supporting UEFI and secure boot are its biggest highlights. It's a big problem today. If you take other distros and try to install them, there's a lot of work that is required for a successful installation. We have tested our software. We purchased the hardware and we tried different distros, including Ubuntu and Fedora, apart from OpenSUSE. In many cases, OpenSUSE was the only one that was installed without any problems. So we are definitely ahead of others with OpenSUSE 12.3. With this version, we are looking ahead to future technologies. Of course, we have some issues to be resolved because it is a pretty new technology.